1737. Change Minimum Characters to Satisfy One of Three Conditions

Solved

Medium Topics Hint

You are given two strings a and b that consist of lowercase letters. In one operation, you can change any character in a or b to **any lowercase letter**.

Your goal is to satisfy **one** of the following three conditions:

- **Every** letter in a is **strictly less** than **every** letter in b in the alphabet.
- **Every** letter in b is **strictly less** than **every** letter in a in the alphabet.
- **Both** a and b consist of **only one** distinct letter.

Return *the **minimum** number of operations needed to achieve your goal.*

Example 1:

> **Input:** a = "aba", b = "caa"
> **Output:** 2
> **Explanation:** Consider the best way to make each condition true:
> 1) Change b to "ccc" in 2 operations, then every letter in a is less than every letter in b.
> 2) Change a to "bbb" and b to "aaa" in 3 operations, then every letter in b is less than every letter in a.
> 3) Change a to "aaa" and b to "aaa" in 2 operations, then a and b consist of one distinct letter.
> The best way was done in 2 operations (either condition 1 or condition 3).

Example 2:

> **Input:** a = "dabadd", b = "cda"
> **Output:** 3
> **Explanation:** The best way is to make condition 1 true by changing b to "eee".

Constraints:

- $1 <= a.length, b.length <= 10^5$
- a and b consist only of lowercase letters.

Seen this question in a real interview before? 1/5

Yes No

Accepted 16,440 /43.5K | Acceptance Rate 37.8 %

Topics

Hint 1

Hint 2

Discussion (8)

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